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The 12-Day Christmas Cleaning Countdown

One task a day, 20 to 30 minutes each, for the 12 days before Christmas. Christmas Eve is a light touch-up, and then you stop.

The one rule: set a timer, do today's task, stop when it rings. Nothing on this page is allowed to take over an evening. Tick the box, close the door on the rest of the house, and the full guide with the why behind every day is on the site.

12 DAY 12 — Declutter the entryway — 25 min

- [ ] Shoes, mail and bags away, surfaces cleared
- [ ] Doormat shaken, floor swept, handle and switch wiped
- [ ] A few hangers freed for guest coats

11 DAY 11 — Guest bathroom deep clean — 30 min

- [ ] Counter cleared, cleaner left to dwell ten minutes
- [ ] Mirror to toilet base, hinges and the floor behind
- [ ] Fresh hand towel, backup toilet paper in reach

10 DAY 10 — Fridge clean out before groceries — 25 min

- [ ] Everything out, expired and forgotten binned
- [ ] Shelves washed, walls wiped with baking soda water
- [ ] Zones set, one shelf kept empty on purpose

9 DAY 9 — Oven and stovetop — 20 min

- [ ] Baking soda paste on the walls and door, left overnight
- [ ] Racks soaking in hot soapy water
- [ ] Stovetop scraped and wiped, knobs and handle degreased

8 DAY 8 — Floors and baseboards, guest areas — 30 min

- [ ] Guest path vacuumed, including edges and under the table
- [ ] Hard floors mopped, far corner to the door
- [ ] Baseboards in the guest rooms only

7 DAY 7 — Dust and light fixtures — 25 min

- [ ] Ceiling fan with the pillowcase trick
- [ ] Dining light, door frames, frames, shelves
- [ ] Lampshades and blinds with the brush attachment

6 DAY 6 — Windows and mirrors — 30 min

- [ ] Half vinegar, half water, dry microfiber, S pattern
- [ ] Front door glass and every mirror on the guest path
- [ ] Window tracks with the crevice tool, sills last

5 DAY 5 — Linens and guest towels — 20 min

- [ ] Guest bed stripped and washed hot, bed made
- [ ] Towels, throws, pillow covers, bath mat washed
- [ ] One hand towel held back for Christmas Eve

4 DAY 4 — Kitchen surfaces and sink shine — 25 min

- [ ] Counters cleared and wiped, cabinet fronts and handles
- [ ] Stainless wiped with the grain and dried
- [ ] Sink scrubbed with baking soda, dried, buffed with lemon

3 DAY 3 — Living room reset — 30 min

- [ ] Cushions off, frame and cushions vacuumed
- [ ] Remotes and switches wiped, surfaces cleared
- [ ] Throws folded, seating counted and pulled in

2 DAY 2 — Trash, recycling and smells — 20 min

- [ ] Every bin emptied and rinsed, recycling out
- [ ] Disposal run with ice and citrus, drains flushed
- [ ] Smell sources found, simmer pot stocked

1 DAY 1 — The 30 minute touch-up, then stop — 30 min

- [ ] Bathroom 8 min, entryway 5, living room 7, kitchen 10
- [ ] Fresh hand towel out, dishwasher emptied, trash out
- [ ] Then stop. Pour something warm.

Starting late? The four evening version

Evening 1	**Days 11 and 12.** Guest bathroom done properly, then the entryway cleared and wiped.
Evening 2	**Days 10 and 4.** Fridge cleared with one empty shelf, counters reset, sink shined, new sponge. Skip the oven unless it smokes.
Evening 3	**Days 8 and 3.** Guest path floors, couch cushions vacuumed, surfaces cleared, bathroom baseboards only.
Evening 4	**Days 2 and 1.** Bins, smells at the source, simmer pot bought, and the 30 minute touch-up on the day.

Notes, and who is bringing what

Bathroom, smells, touch-up. If you only do three days, do those.